Sharing news and great stories from the South of the Dinokeng Game Reserve

THE BUSH TELEGRAPH

WILDLY GOOD NEWS

Keeping the Balance, Why Live Game Capture Is An Important Part of Managing DGR

Seeing wildlife roaming freely is one of the great attractions of DGR. But maintaining healthy wildlife populations involves more than protecting animals and allowing nature to take its course and in a relatively small, enclosed reserve, it also means carefully managing animal numbers to ensure the veld can continue to support them.

Every year, following consultation with ecologists and consideration of data from previous game censuses, a game off-take quota is approved by DGE. This determines how many animals of particular species may be removed from the reserve during the year as part of the wildlife management programme.

This year, just before the end of the live capture season, specialist game capture teams were contracted to capture and sell the remaining animals allocated under the approved quota.

WHY DO WE NEED TO REMOVE ANIMALS?

The answer lies in the relationship between wildlife and the habitat they depend on.

The number of animals a reserve can sustainably support, known as its carrying capacity, is influenced by many factors. These include the availability and quality of vegetation, rainfall, temperature, drought conditions and the changing needs of different species.

When animal populations exceed what the available habitat can sustain, pressure on vegetation increases. Overgrazing and excessive browsing can damage the veld, affect its ability to recover and ultimately threaten the very habitat on which wildlife depends.

By monitoring animal numbers and managing populations through an approved off-take programme, DGR can help maintain a sustainable balance between wildlife and the natural environment.









Why not simply introduce more predators?

It is a question worth considering. Surely more lions or other predators would naturally reduce antelope numbers?

While predators certainly play an important role in regulating prey populations, it is not that straightforward in a reserve the size of DGR. Predators need suitable territories, sufficient prey and enough space to maintain healthy populations. Their numbers are also limited by the reserve's carrying capacity.

We cannot simply keep introducing more predators whenever antelope numbers increase. Doing so could create new pressures and imbalances rather than solve the original problem. Predators are an important part of the ecosystem, but they cannot be relied upon as the only tool for managing wildlife populations in a relatively small, enclosed reserve like DGR.



A CAREFULLY MANAGED PROCESS

Live game capture provides a practical way to remove selected animals while allowing them to be transported and sold to other wildlife operations.

The process is informed by census data, ecological advice and an approved quota. It is not simply a matter of removing as many animals as possible. The objective is to manage populations responsibly, with the long-term health of the reserve in mind.

Ultimately, successful conservation is about balance. It means protecting wildlife while also protecting the land, water and vegetation that sustain it.

A healthy reserve is not measured only by how many animals it holds, but by whether the ecosystem can continue to support them for generations to come.

The Bush Telegraph, Connecting Our Community, One Story at a Time.

An independent newsletter celebrating conservation, community and the people of DGR.

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